

28 July 2026

The National Food Council (the Council) met on Tuesday 28 July 2026, in Melbourne. The meeting was chaired by the Secretary of the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Victoria Anderson.

The Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, the Hon Julie Collins MP, addressed the Council, providing an update on the evolving H5 bird flu situation and government actions in response to ongoing conflict in the Middle East.

The Minister reaffirmed that there have been no detections of H5 bird flu in Australia's poultry and agriculture systems, and that Australia's food security remains strong through investments made in preparedness and our biosecurity systems.

The Council received a briefing on, and reflected on the substantial progress that has been made over the past year, including:

- Engagement of over 400 stakeholders from across the food system on the National Food Security Strategy discussion paper.
- An extensive consultation and co-design process involving over 450 stakeholders from across the food supply chain.
- Ongoing analysis of Australia's food system, including its strengths, vulnerabilities and future opportunities.

Minister Collins and the Council noted this work ensures the Strategy is being built on a strong foundation of evidence, analysis and stakeholder input.

The Council worked through the key themes that emerged from the consultation process, considered the work undertaken by the department on its analysis of the food system, and discussed how the themes and other evidence collected might be refined as the Strategy is developed.

The Council will meet again in October.

#### Attendees

- Dr Christopher Downs
- Simeon Gilding
- Barry Irvin AM
- Dr Liz Jackson
- Dr Leisa McCarthy
- Claire McClelland
- Su McCluskey
- Dr Tracy Sullivan
- Victoria Anderson, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (Chair)
- Matt Lowe, Deputy Secretary, Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry Policy Group
- Joanna Stanion, First Assistant Secretary, Agricultural Policy Division
- Paul Denny, Assistant Secretary, Food Policy Branch

## Guest attendees

- Mr John Body, ThinkPlace

## Apologies

- Mel Gatfield
- Pat O'Shannassy
- David Stout

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/national-food-council-july-2026>